If you've ever walked past your own colleague, or failed to recognise a friend out of context, and quietly built a life around covering for it — there's a name for that. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, is difficulty recognising faces, including very familiar ones. Developmental prosopagnosia is present from birth and affects around two percent of people. It has nothing to do with memory, attention or caring — the face-processing system simply works differently. Most people compensate using voice, hair, gait and context.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Recognising people by coat, voice or walk, and being lost when they change any of it.
- Watching a film and losing track of which character is which.
- Greeting everyone warmly as insurance, in case you know them.
- Not recognising your own face in a group photograph.
- Being thought rude or standoffish for years.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"You're bad with names."	Different thing. Names can be perfect; the face is what won't attach.
"You weren't paying attention."	Attention doesn't help. The processing happens elsewhere.
"You don't care about people."	Frequently the reverse — the anxiety about causing offence is constant.
"Everyone forgets faces sometimes."	Not their own family's, reliably, forever.
"You recognised me last week!"	Context did that. Same person, different setting, different outcome.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Strong recognition of voice, gait and mannerism.

Excellent contextual and situational memory.

Judges people on behaviour rather than appearance.

Highly developed social workarounds.

Genuinely unbiased about looks.

What actually helps

- ☐ Say your name when you greet them
- ☐ Keep hair, glasses, coat predictable if you can
- ☐ Don't take being missed personally
- ☐ Don't test them or make it a joke
- ☐ Introduce yourself again, cheerfully
- ☐ Mention who's in the room quietly

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"Hi, it's me, Dave."

"No bother at all."

"Sarah's the one in blue."

LESS HELPFUL

"Guess who!"

"You don't remember me?"

"How can you not know my face?"

Not rudeness, not carelessness. A face-shaped gap in an otherwise fine memory.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk